



WONBIN SSEM · KOREAN

100 Essential Korean Adjectives

Real spoken Korean, straight from daily life

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How to Get the Most Out of This Guide

A few notes before you dive in — read these once, then enjoy the adjectives.

Dictionary form → spoken form

Each adjective shows its **dictionary form** (e.g. 크다) with its everyday **spoken form** right beside it (커요). Korean adjectives change shape a lot, so every tip breaks down **exactly how** the form is built — the ㅂ → 우, the dropped ㅡ, the ㄹ → ㄷㄹ, and more.

Real spoken Korean over textbooks

Every example is pulled from real daily conversations, with the missing particles and dropped pronouns that native speakers naturally leave out. That's how you learn to sound natural, not like a textbook.

Grammar, nuance & culture in every tip

Under each word: how to conjugate it, the modifier form (-**(으)ㄴ**) and adverb form (-**게**) when the example uses them, plus the idioms, softeners, and **when** Koreans actually reach for the word.

Make it yours

Build your own sentences about your day, your mood, the weather, the food in front of you. Personalizing these patterns is what makes them stick.

Want to dive deeper?

For 1-on-1 feedback, real-time practice, and even more real-life expressions — [book a class with me at wonbinssem.com](https://wonbinssem.com). Let's make you fluently conversational in Korean together. 🙌

크다 to be big

SPOKEN 커요 kuh-yo

와 집 진짜 커요

wa jip jin-jja kuh-yo

Wow, your place is really big!

- 와** 'wow' — an exclamation that opens with surprise/admiration.
- 진짜** 'really' (intensifier). In speech it's used far more than 정말.
- 커요** — **irregular**: 크+어요 drops the — → **커요**. Before a noun use 큰 (큰 집).
- 집(이)** 'place/home.' Full form is **집이 커요**, but the subject marker **이** is usually dropped in speech.

작다 to be small

SPOKEN 작아요 ja-ga-yo

제 방은 작아요

je bang-eun ja-ga-yo

My room is small.

- 제** 'my' (humble, short for 저의).
- 은/는** 방+은. The topic marker — 'as for my room...', gently spotlighting it.
- 작아요** Regular: 작+아요 (last vowel ㅏ → **아요**). Before a noun: 작은.

많다 to be many / a lot

SPOKEN 많아요 ma-na-yo

여기 맛있는 거 왜 이렇게 많아요?

yuh-gi ma-shin-neun guh we i-ruh-ke ma-na-yo?

Why is there so much good food here?

- 는 거** 'the tasty stuff.' **verb/adj + 는 거** bundles it into a noun ('the ~ thing').
- 왜 이렇게 ~** Literally 'why so,' but really an **exclamation** ('wow, so much!'), not an actual why-question.
- 많아요** Regular (받침 ㅈ). Said **[마나요]** — the ㅎ drops and ㄴ links over.

적다 to be few / little

SPOKEN 적어요 juh-guh-yo

이게 돈 더 적게 들어요

i-ge don duh juh-kke deu-ruh-yo

This costs less.

- 이게** 'this' (short for 이것이 = 이거 + 가).
- 더** 'more' (comparative). It modifies **적게** → 'even less.'
- 적게** 적다 + **게** → adverb 'less.' It describes how much is spent.
- 들다** Here 들다 = '(cost) is incurred.' 돈이 들다 = to cost money.

넓다 to be wide / spacious

SPOKEN 넓어요 nuhl-buh-yo

여기 사람들 다 알아요? 발이 진짜 넓네요

yuh-gi sa-ram-deul da a-ra-yo? ba-ri jin-jja nuhl-ne-yo

You know everyone here? You're so well-connected!

다 'all / everyone' (adverb). 사람들 다 = everybody.

-아요? (Q) Rising intonation turns a plain statement into a question. 알아요? = do you know?

발이 넓다 An idiom! Not literal wide feet — it means **well-connected, knows everyone**.

-네요 An ending for reacting to something just noticed ('oh, you really are!').

좁다 to be narrow

SPOKEN 좁아요 jo-ba-yo

여기 좁아서 지나가기 힘들어요

yuh-gi jo-ba-suh ji-na-ga-gi him-deu-ruh-yo

It's narrow here, so it's hard to get through.

여기 'here' — pointing at the cramped spot.

-아/어서 Reason 'because ~.' 좁아서 = because it's narrow.

-기 힘들다 Nominalize 지나가다 as 지나가 + 기, then add 힘들다 → 'hard to do.' verb + 기 힘들다 = hard to ~.

길다 to be long

SPOKEN 길어요 gi-ruh-yo

길게 봐야죠

gil-ge bwa-ya-jyo

You've got to take the long view.

길게 길다 + 게 → adverb. 길게 보다 = take a long-term view (not about length).

-아/어야 'have to ~.' 봐야 = must look (at it).

-죠 Short for -지요 — a soft ending that assumes the listener agrees ('...right?').

짧다 to be short

SPOKEN 짧아요 jjal-ba-yo

짧은 시간이었지만 너무 좋았어요

jjal-beun shi-ga-ni-uh-t-jji-man nuh-moo jo-a-ssuh-yo

It was a short time, but it was wonderful.

-(으)ㄴ adj + (으)ㄴ modifies a noun. 짧은 시간 = a short time. (받침 ㄴ, said [짧븐].)

-지만 'although ~.' It contrasts the two halves of the sentence.

너무 'so / very' (intensifier), boosting 좋았어요.

-았어요 Past of 좋다 (좋+았어요). Said [조아써요].

높다 to be high / tall

SPOKEN 높아요 no-pa-yo

더 높은 곳으로 가야죠

duh no-peun go-seu-ro ga-ya-jyo

We should aim higher.

더 'more.' It boosts 높은 → 'higher.'

-(으)ㄴ 곳 높다 + (으)ㄴ = 높은, + 곳 (place) → 'a high place.'

(으)로 Direction 'toward.' 으로 after a consonant, 로 after a vowel.

-야죠 'we ought to go.' **-야죠** = should (obligation) + shared agreement.

낮다 to be low

SPOKEN 낮아요 na-ja-yo

제가 눈이 좀 낮아요

je-ga noo-ni jom na-ja-yo

My standards are pretty low (I'm not picky).

눈이 낮다 An idiom: 'to have easy-going standards.' The opposite of 눈이 높다 (picky).

좀 Literally 'a little,' but here a **softening cushion** — it takes the edge off a blunt statement.

낮아요 Regular: 낮+아요. Said [나자요].

두껍다 to be thick

SPOKEN 두꺼워요 doo-kkuh-wuh-yo

오늘 꽤 추우니 옷 두껍게 입어요

o-neul kkwe choo-oo-ni ot doo-kkuhp-kke i-buh-yo

It's pretty cold today, so dress warm.

꽤 'quite / pretty' — colder than you'd expect.

-(으)니 Reason 'since ~.' 춥다 is ㅂ **irregular** → 추우 + 니.

두껍게 두껍다 + 게 → adverb. 두껍게 입다 = dress in thick, warm layers.

-아/어요 (suggest) Said with a gentle falling tone, this works as '(you should) dress warm,' a soft suggestion.

얇다 to be thin

SPOKEN 얇아요 yal-ba-yo

제 옷 생각보다 얇아서 그렇게 안 더워요

je ot seng-gak-ppo-da yal-ba-suh geu-ruh-ke an duh-wuh-yo

My clothes are thinner than they look, so I'm not that hot.

-보다 Comparison 'than ~.' 생각보다 = than I thought.

-아/어서 Reason 'because they're thin.' (받침 ㅅ, said [얇아서].)

그렇게 'that much.' It modifies 안 더워요.

안 + predicate Negation 안 sits right before the predicate. 안 더워요 = not hot (덥다 → 더워요, ㅂ irregular).

무겁다 to be heavy

SPOKEN 무거워요 moo-guh-wuh-yo

무거운 것 같은데 도와줄까요?

moo-guh-ool guht ga-teun-de do-wa-jool-kka-yo?

That looks heavy — want some help?

-(으)ㄴ 것 같다 Guessing 'seems ~.' 무겁다 → 무거운 것 같다 = looks heavy (ㄹ irregular).

-는데 -ㄴ데/는데 sets the scene and leads into the next clause ('it looks heavy, so...').

-(으)까요? Offering 'shall I ~?'. 도와줄까요? = want some help?

가볍다 to be light

SPOKEN 가벼워요 ga-byuh-wuh-yo

아니요 가벼워서 괜찮아요

a-ni-yo ga-byuh-wuh-suh gwen-cha-na-yo

No, it's light, so I'm fine.

아니요 'no' — politely declining the offer of help.

-아/어서 Reason 'because it's light.' (ㄹ irregular → 가벼워요.)

괜찮아요 'I'm fine / no need.' The standard way to wave off help.

CATEGORY 2 Comparison & Judgment

비교 · 판단

똑같다 to be identical

SPOKEN 똑같아요 ttok-kka-ta-yo

사람 사는 거 다 똑같구나

sa-ram sa-neun guh da ttok-kkat-kkoo-na

People live the same way everywhere, huh.

-는 거 'the way (people) live.' V+는 거 turns a clause into a noun.

다 'all / everywhere.'

-구나 An ending for a personal realization ('ah, I see'). 똑같다 = exactly the same (stronger than 같다).

다르다 to be different

SPOKEN 달라요 dal-la-yo

그때마다 달라요

geu-tte-ma-da dal-la-yo

It's different every time.

-마다 'every time.' -마다 = 'each / every.'

다르다 르 irregular (르 → 르르). Careful: 다르다 ('different') ≠ 틀리다 ('wrong').

비슷하다 to be similar

SPOKEN 비슷해요 *bi-seu-te-yo*

저도 그거랑 비슷한 거 있어요!

juh-do geu-guh-rang bi-seu-tan guh i-ssuh-yo!

I have something similar to that too!

- 도 'me too.'
- 랑 'to/with that.' -랑 = 'with.'
- (으)ㄴ 거 'something similar.' 비슷하 + ㄴ = 비슷한, + 거 (thing).

맞다 to be correct / right

SPOKEN 맞아요 *ma-ja-yo*

맞아요 완전 공감해요

ma-ja-yo wan-juhn gong-gam-he-yo

Right, I totally agree.

- 맞다 The everyday 'exactly! / that's right!' (맞다 also = 'to fit / be hit,' by context.)
- 완전 'totally.' 완전 공감해요 = 'I totally relate.'

아니다 to not be

SPOKEN 아니에요 *a-ni-e-yo*

아닌 경우도 많아요

a-nin gyuhng-oo-do ma-na-yo

There are plenty of cases where that's not so.

- 아닌 'cases where it isn't.' The negative of 이다. Alone, 아니에요 = a polite 'no / not at all.'
- 도 'also / too.' 경우도 = 'cases too.'

CATEGORY 3 Appearance

외모 · 인상

예쁘다 to be pretty

SPOKEN 예뻐요 *ye-ppuh-yo*

왜 이렇게 예뻐요?

we i-ruh-ke ye-ppuh-yo?

Why are you so pretty?

- 왜 이렇게 ~ Not a real 'why' — an admiring exclamation ('you're SO pretty!').
- 예쁘다 — **irregular** (— drops → 예뻐요). Modifier 예쁜 (예쁜 옷).

잘생기다 to be handsome

SPOKEN 잘생겼어요 *jal-seng-gyuh-ssuh-yo*

잘생긴 남자친구 사귀고 싶어요

jal-seng-gin nam-ja-chin-goo sa-gwi-go shi-puh-yo

I want to date a handsome guy.

- 잘생긴 Modifier 'handsome.' Almost always the fixed 잘생겼어요 form (a lasting state); you rarely hear 잘생겨요.
- 고 싶다 Desire 'want to ~.' 사귀다 = 'to date.'

귀엽다 to be cute

SPOKEN 귀여워요 gwi-yuh-wuh-yo

제 강아지 귀엽죠?

je gang-a-ji gwi-yuhp-jjyo?

My puppy's cute, right?

강아지(가) 'puppy' (subject; 가 dropped).

-죠? Tag '~right?' fishing for agreement. 귀엽다 → 귀여워요 (ㅁ irregular).

멋있다 to be cool / awesome

SPOKEN 멋있어요 muh-shi-ssuh-yo

진짜 멋진 인생을 살고 있네요

jin-jja muht-jjin in-seng-eul sal-go in-ne-yo

You're living a truly awesome life.

멋지다 Twin form of 멋있다; modifier 멋진 (멋진 인생).

-고 있다 + -네요 Progressive 'are living' + 네요 (a warm, just-noticed reaction).

아름답다 to be beautiful

SPOKEN 아름다워요 a-reum-da-wuh-yo

세상에서 제일 아름다워요

se-sang-e-suh je-il a-reum-da-wuh-yo

You're the most beautiful in the world.

-에서 'in the world.'

제일 'the most.'

아름답다 ㅁ irregular. More poetic than 예쁘다 — for scenery, art, deep beauty.

사랑스럽다 to be lovely / adorable

SPOKEN 사랑스러워요 sa-rang-seu-ruh-wuh-yo

얼마 전에 태어난 제 조카 진짜 사랑스러워요

uhl-ma juh-ne te-uh-nan je jo-ka jin-jja sa-rang-seu-ruh-wuh-yo

My niece who was just born is so adorable.

얼마 전에 'a little while ago.'

-(으)ㄴ '(who was) born.' Past modifier of 태어나다.

-스럽다 Suffix ~스럽다 = 'gives off the feeling of ~.' (ㅁ irregular → 사랑스러워요.)

친절하다 to be kind

SPOKEN 친절해요 chin-juhl-he-yo

한국 사람들 너무 친절해요

han-gook sa-ram-deul nuh-moo chin-juhl-he-yo

Korean people are so kind.

너무 'so' — here positive ('so kind').**친절하다** 하다 stem → 친절해요. A top compliment about Korean people and service.

똑똑하다 to be smart

SPOKEN 똑똑해요 ttok-tto-ke-yo

똑똑한 스타일은 아니어서 열심히 노력해요

ttok-tto-kan seu-ta-i-reun a-ni-uh-suh yuhl-shim-hi no-ryuh-ke-yo

I'm not the brainy type, so I work hard.

-(으)ㄴ 'smart' (modifier).**-아/어서** 'since I'm not the ~ type' — a humble flip.**열심히** 'hard / diligently.'

착하다 to be nice / good-hearted

SPOKEN 착해요 cha-ke-yo

제 이상형은 착한 사람이에요

je i-sang-hyuhng-eun cha-kan sa-ra-mi-e-yo

My ideal type is a kind-hearted person.

-은/는 'as for my ideal type.' 이상형 = ideal type.**-(으)ㄴ** 'a kind-hearted person' — about a good heart, not looks.

대단하다 to be amazing / impressive

SPOKEN 대단해요 de-dan-he-yo

○○ 씨 대단한데요?

○○ ssi de-dan-han-de-yo?

Wow, you're impressive!

-씨 'Mr./Ms.' — a polite suffix after a name.**-(으)ㄴ데요** An impressed 'nice, wow!' ~ㄴ데요 softens it into a warm reaction.

친하다 to be close (friends)

SPOKEN 친해요 chin-he-yo

그 사람이랑 잘 맞아서 금방 친해졌어요

geu sa-ra-mi-rang jal ma-ja-suh geum-bang chin-he-jyuh-ssuh-yo

We clicked, so we got close fast.

-아/어서 'because we click.' 잘 맞다 = to click / be compatible.

금방 'quickly / soon.'

-아/어지다 'became close.' 친하 + ~아지다 = a change of state.

건강하다 to be healthy

SPOKEN 건강해요 guhn-gang-he-yo

건강하세요! 아프지 마세요!

guhn-gang-ha-se-yo! a-peu-ji ma-se-yo!

Stay healthy! Don't get sick!

-(으)세요 As a farewell, a warm 'stay healthy!' to elders.

-지 마세요 'don't get sick.' Prohibition 'don't ~.'

CATEGORY 5 Condition — Clean, New & Safe

상태 · 청결 · 새것 · 안전

깨끗하다 to be clean

SPOKEN 깨끗해요 kke-kkeu-te-yo

제 집 지금 깨끗하지 않아서 ㅎㅎ

je jip ji-geum kke-kkeu-ta-ji a-na-suh ㅎㅎ

My place isn't clean right now haha.

지금 'right now.'

-지 않다 Negation 'isn't ~.' 깨끗하지 않다 = not clean (+아서 trails into an excuse).

ㅎㅎ A little 'haha' that softens the confession — very texting-native.

더럽다 to be dirty

SPOKEN 더러워요 duh-ruh-wuh-yo

이거 자주 더러워져요

i-guh ja-joo duh-ruh-wuh-jyuh-yo

This gets dirty often.

자주 'often.'

-아/어지다 'gets dirty.' Change-of-state 더러워지다. (더럽다 ㅂ irregular → 더러워요.)

새롭다 to be new

SPOKEN 새로워요 se-ro-wuh-yo

저기 새로운 식당 가볼래요?

juh-gi se-ro-oon shik-ttang ga-bol-le-yo?

Want to try that new restaurant?

-(으)ㄴ 'new' (modifier). (새롭다 ㅂ irregular → 새로워요.) For a brand-new object, 새 works: 새 옷.

-(으)ㄹ래요? Casual suggestion 'shall we / wanna ~?'

오래되다 to be old (things)

SPOKEN 오래됐어요 o-re-dwe-ssuh-yo

지금 애인이랑 만난 지 꽤 오래됐어요

ji-geum e-i-ni-rang man-nan ji kkwe o-re-dwe-ssuh-yo

I've been with my partner for quite a while now.

-(으)ㄴ 지 'since ~ing.' Marks elapsed time. 만난 지 = since we met.

꽤 'quite.'

오래되다 'it's been a while.' For things & relationships — NOT people (for age, 나이가 들다).

안전하다 to be safe

SPOKEN 안전해요 an-juhn-he-yo

이거 안전한 거 확실하죠?

i-guh an-juhn-han guh hwak-ssil-ha-jyo?

This is definitely safe, right?

-(으)ㄴ 거 'the fact that it's safe.'

-죠? Confirm-tag 'for sure, right?'

위험하다 to be dangerous

SPOKEN 위험해요 wi-huhm-he-yo

위험하진 않아요?

wi-huhm-ha-jin a-na-yo?

It's not dangerous, is it?

-지(는) 않다 'it's not dangerous, is it?' 위험하지는 → 위험하진 (spoken contraction) — a worried check.

CATEGORY 6 Difficulty & Possibility

난이도 · 가능성

쉽다 to be easy

SPOKEN 쉬워요 swi-wuh-yo

하.. 쉽지 않네요

ha.. swip-jji an-ne-yo

Ugh... it's not easy.

하.. 'haa..' — a small sigh.

-지 않다 + -네요 'not easy.' ~네요 adds a live 'I'm feeling it' reaction. (쉽다 → 쉬워요, ㅂ irregular.)

어렵다 to be difficult

SPOKEN 어려워요 uh-ryuh-wuh-yo

한국어 문법 너무 어려워요..

han-goo-guh moon-buhp nuh-moo uh-ryuh-wuh-yo..

Korean grammar is so hard..

문법 'grammar.'

너무 'so.'

어렵다 ㅂ irregular. The trailing dots carry a little sigh.

간단하다 to be simple

SPOKEN간단해요 gan-dan-he-yo

간단한 건데 잘 안되네요

gan-dan-han guhn-de jal an-dwe-ne-yo

It's a simple thing, but it's not working.

-(으)ㄴ데 'it's a simple thing, but...' ~ㄴ데 sets up a contrast.

안되다 + -네요 'it's not working.' 안되다 = to not work out.

복잡하다 to be complicated

SPOKEN복잡해요 bok-jja-pe-yo

너무 복잡하게 생각하지 마요

nuh-moo bok-jja-pa-ge seng-ga-ka-ji ma-yo

Don't overthink it.

-게 'in a complicated way.' Adjective + 게 → adverb.

-지 마요 Prohibition 'don't ~.' = 'don't overthink it.'

가능하다 to be possible

SPOKEN가능해요 ga-neung-he-yo

충분히 가능할 거 같은데요?

choong-boon-hi ga-neung-hal guh ga-teun-de-yo?

I think it's totally doable, right?

충분히 'plenty / totally.'

-(으)ㄹ 거 같다 + -ㄴ데요 Guess 'seems possible' + soft ~ㄴ데요 = 'it's doable, right?'

불가능하다 to be impossible

SPOKEN불가능해요 bool-ga-neung-he-yo

아 이걸 완전 불가능

a i-guhn wan-juhn bool-ga-neung

Ah, this is totally impossible.

-은/는 'this' (이것은 → 이걸, topic).

완전 + noun In casual speech Koreans clip 해요 for punch: 완전 불가능 = 'totally impossible.'

좋다 to be good / niceSPOKEN **좋아요** jo-a-yo좋은 사람 소개시켜 주세요

jo-eun sa-ram so-ge-shi-kyuh joo-se-yo

Set me up with a nice person.

-(으)ㄴ 'a nice person.' Careful: 좋다 (adj, 'be good') ≠ 좋아하다 (verb, 'to like').**-아/어 주세요** Favor 'please set me up.' 소개시키다 = to introduce / set up.**나쁘다** to be badSPOKEN **나빠요** na-ppa-yo나쁘지 않았어요

na-ppeu-ji a-na-ssuh-yo

It wasn't bad (= pretty good).

-지 않다 'wasn't bad.' Litotes — a very Korean way to say 'actually quite good.' (나쁘다 — irregular → 나빠요.)**괜찮다** to be okay / fineSPOKEN **괜찮아요** gwen-cha-na-yo괜찮아요 제가 좀 바빠서요

gwen-cha-na-yo je-ga jom ba-ppa-suh-yo

No thanks, I'm a bit busy.

괜찮다 'it's fine' — but ALSO the polite way to **decline** ('no thanks, I'm good').**-아/어서요** 'because I'm busy.' ~서요 softly trails off a reason.**중요하다** to be importantSPOKEN **중요해요** joong-yo-he-yo그렇게 중요한 거 아니에요

geu-ruh-ke joong-yo-han guh a-ni-e-yo

It's not that big a deal.

그렇게 'that (much).'**-(으)ㄴ 거 아니다** 'it's not (such) an important thing' — downplaying it.**필요하다** to be necessarySPOKEN **필요해요** pi-ryo-he-yo필요하면 말해요!

pi-ryo-ha-myuhn mal-he-yo!

Let me know if you need it!

-(으)면 'if (you) need.' Conditional 'if ~.' Takes 이/가 (도움이 필요해요), not 을/를.**말해요** 'tell me / let me know.'

급하다 to be urgent

SPOKEN 급해요 *geu-pe-yo*

급한 일이 생겨서 가봐야 해요

geu-pan i-ri seng-gyuh-suh ga-bwa-ya he-yo

Something urgent came up, so I have to go.

-(으)ㄴ 'an urgent matter.'

-아/어서 'because (it) came up.' 생기자 = to come up / arise.

-아/어야 하다 'I have to get going.'

아깝다 to be a waste / a pity

SPOKEN 아까워요 *a-kka-wuh-yo*

아깝지만 어쩔 수 없죠

a-kkap-jji-man uh-jjuhl soo uhp-jjyo

It's a shame, but it can't be helped.

-지만 'it's a shame, but...' That bittersweet 'what a waste.' (아깝다 ㅁ irregular → 아까워요.)

어쩔 수 없다 'it can't be helped.' A resigned set phrase.

소중하다 to be precious

SPOKEN 소중해요 *so-joong-he-yo*

소중하게 보관할게요 고마워요

so-joong-ha-ge bo-gwan-hal-ge-yo go-ma-wuh-yo

I'll treasure it. Thank you.

-게 'preciously / carefully.' Adjective + 게 → adverb.

-(으)ր게요 'I'll keep it.' A heartfelt thanks for a gift.

비싸다 to be expensive

SPOKEN 비싸요 *bi-ssa-yo*

한국에서 과일 너무 비싸서 잘 못 먹어요

han-goo-ge-suh gwa-il nuh-moo bi-ssa-suh jal mot muh-guh-yo

Fruit is so expensive in Korea, I rarely eat it.

-아/어서 'because it's pricey.'

잘 못 ~ 'can hardly ~.' 잘 못 = 'not well / rarely able to.'

싸다 to be cheap

SPOKEN 싸요 *ssa-yo*

이거 제 나라랑 비교하면 진짜 싸 거예요

i-guh je na-ra-rang bi-gyo-ha-myuhn jin-jja ssan guh-ye-yo

Compared to my country, this is really cheap.

-랑 + -(으)면 'compared with (my) country.' 비교하다 = to compare.

-(으)ㄴ 거예요 'it's a cheap one.' (싸다 also = 'to wrap,' by context.)

기쁘다 to be glad

SPOKEN 기뻐요 gi-ppuh-yo

기쁜 소식 있어요!

gi-ppeun so-shik i-ssuh-yo!

I have good news!

-(으)ㄴ 'good news' (기쁜 = glad; 소식 = news). Warmer than 좋아요. (— irregular → 기뻐요.)

있어요 'I have ~.'

슬프다 to be sad

SPOKEN 슬퍼요 seul-puh-yo

좀 슬프지만 어쩔 수 없죠

jom seul-peu-ji-man uh-jjuhl soo uhp-jjyo

It's a bit sad, but what can you do.

좀 'a bit' — softens it.

-지만 'it's a bit sad, but...' (슬프다 — irregular → 슬퍼요.)

어쩔 수 없다 'nothing to be done.'

즐겁다 to be joyful / fun

SPOKEN 즐거워요 jeul-guh-wuh-yo

오늘 진짜 즐거웠어요

o-neul jin-jja jeul-guh-wuh-ssuh-yo

I had a really great time today.

진짜 'really.'

-았/었어요 Past 'had a great time.' A lovely thing to say after hanging out. (ㅂ irregular → 즐거워요.)

행복하다 to be happy

SPOKEN 행복해요 heng-bo-ke-yo

뭐 할 때 행복해요?

mwuh hal tte heng-bo-ke-yo?

When are you (at your) happiest?

-(으)ㄹ 때 'when doing what.' ~ㄹ 때 = 'when ~ing.'

행복하다 Deeper and more lasting than 기쁘다.

신나다 to be excited / pumped

SPOKEN 신나요 shin-na-yo

오늘 왜 이렇게 신났어요?

o-neul we i-ruh-ke shin-na-ssuh-yo?

Why are you so hyped today?

왜 이렇게 ~ A playful 'why so ~?' — really just reacting to your energy.

신나다 Past 신났어요 — the bubbly, can't-sit-still excited.

화나다 to be angry

SPOKEN 화나요 hwa-na-yo

화났지만 참았어요

hwa-nat-jji-man cha-ma-ssuh-yo

I was angry, but I held it in.

-지만 'I was angry, but...' Related: 화내다 = to show anger.

참다 'held it in.' 참다 = to hold back / endure.

무섭다 to be scary / scared

SPOKEN 무서워요 moo-suh-wuh-yo

그 사람 좀 무서웠어요

geu sa-ram jom moo-suh-wuh-ssuh-yo

That person was kind of intimidating.

좀 'kind of' — softens it.

무섭다 Two readings: 'X is scary' OR 'I'm scared' — context decides. (ㅂ irregular → 무서워요.)

부끄럽다 to be embarrassed / shy

SPOKEN 부끄러워요 boo-kkeu-ruh-wuh-yo

아 진짜 부끄러워요.. 그만해요

a jin-jja boo-kkeu-ruh-wuh-yo.. geu-man-he-yo

Ah, I'm so embarrassed.. stop it.

부끄럽다 That blushing, 'stop teasing me' feeling. (ㅂ irregular.)

그만해요 'quit it / stop.'

놀랍다 to be surprising / amazing

SPOKEN 놀라워요 nol-la-wuh-yo

진짜 반전이어서 완전 놀랐어요

jin-jja ban-juh-ni-uh-suh wan-juhn nol-la-ssuh-yo

It was such a twist, I was totally shocked.

-아/어서 'because it was a twist.' 반전 = a plot twist.

완전 'totally.'

놀라다 For YOUR reaction use the verb 놀라다 → 놀랐어요 ('got surprised'), not the adjective 놀랍다.

외롭다 to be lonely

SPOKEN 외로워요 we-ro-wuh-yo

원래 괜찮았는데 요즘은 좀 외로워요

wuhl-le gwen-cha-nan-neun-de yo-jeu-meun jom we-ro-wuh-yo

I used to be fine, but lately I feel a bit lonely.

원래 'originally / used to.'

-는데 'I was fine, but...' ~는데 leads into the contrast.

-은/는 'but these days.' (외롭다 ㅂ irregular → 외로워요.)

싫다 to dislike / be unpleasant

SPOKEN 싫어요 *shi-ruh-yo*

싫으면 싫다고 해도 돼요

shi-reu-myuhn shil-ta-go he-do dwe-yo

If you don't like it, you can just say so.

-(으)면 'if you don't like it.' An adjective for YOUR feeling, vs the verb 싫어하다.

-다고 하다 'you can say (you) dislike it.' 싫다고 하다 = to say 'I dislike it' (reported speech).

피곤하다 to be tired

SPOKEN 피곤해요 *pi-gon-he-yo*

피곤해서 먼저 들어가 볼게요!

pi-gon-he-suh muhn-juh deu-ruh-ga bol-ge-yo!

I'm tired, so I'll head home first!

-아/어서 'because I'm tired.'

먼저 'first / before others.'

-아/어 볼게요 'I'll head in.' The polite way to excuse yourself and leave first.

CATEGORY 9 Feelings, Attitude & Daily Life

태도 · 상태 · 일상

편안하다 to be comfortable / relaxed

SPOKEN 편안해요 *pyuh-nan-he-yo*

이 의자 너무 편안해요

i ui-ja nuh-moo pyuh-nan-he-yo

This chair is so comfortable.

이 의자 'this chair.'

너무 'so.'

편안하다 Often clipped to 편해요. For physical comfort or ease of mind.

긴장되다 to be nervous

SPOKEN 긴장돼요 *gin-jang-dwe-yo*

긴장 안 하려고 해도 너무 떨려요

gin-jang an ha-ryuh-go he-do nuh-moo ttuhl-lyuh-yo

Even trying not to be nervous, I'm shaking.

-(으)려고 하다 + -아/어도 'even trying not to.' ~려고 하다 = 'try / intend to.'

떨리다 'I'm shaking.' 긴장되다 = feel nervous; active 긴장하다 = to get nervous.

자연스럽다 to be natural

SPOKEN 자연스러워요 *ja-yuhn-seu-ruh-wuh-yo*

자연스럽게 행동해요. 안 걸릴 거예요

ja-yuhn-seu-ruh-p-kke heng-dong-he-yo. an guhl-lil guh-ye-yo

Act natural. We won't get caught.

-게 'naturally / casually.' Adjective + 게 → adverb. (ㄹ irregular → 자연스러워요.)

-(으)ㄹ 거예요 'we won't get caught.' 걸리다 here = to get caught.

고맙다 to be thankful

SPOKEN 고마워요 *go-ma-wuh-yo*

제가 힘들 때 도와주는 진짜 고마운 사람이에요

je-ga him-deul tte do-wa-joo-neun jin-jja go-ma-oon sa-ra-mi-e-yo

They're someone I'm truly grateful to for helping me in hard times.

-(으)ㄹ 때 'when I'm struggling.'

V+는 '(who) helps me.' Present modifier.

고맙다 Modifier 'grateful.' 고마워요 (warm) vs 감사합니다 (formal). (ㄹ irregular.)

미안하다 to be sorry

SPOKEN 미안해요 *mi-an-he-yo*

자꾸 미안한 감정이 들어요

ja-kkoo mi-an-han gam-juhng-i deu-ruh-yo

I keep feeling sorry.

자꾸 'repeatedly / keep ~ing.'

감정이 들다 'a feeling of guilt arises.' 감정이 들다 = to feel an emotion. Casual 미안 / formal 죄송해요.

바쁘다 to be busy

SPOKEN 바빠요 *ba-ppa-yo*

최근에 너무 바빴어요

chwe-geu-ne nuh-moo ba-ppa-ssuh-yo

I've been so busy lately.

-에 'recently / lately.'

바쁘다 Past. Common excuse: 바빠서 못 갔어요. (ㄹ irregular → 바빠요.)

재미있다 to be fun / interesting

SPOKEN 재미있어요 *je-mi-i-ssuh-yo*

오늘 너무 재미있었어요

o-neul nuh-moo je-mi-i-ssuh-ssuh-yo

Today was so much fun.

너무 'so.'

-았/었어요 Past 'that was fun.' Often shortened to 재밌어요 in speech.

재미없다 to be boring / not fun

SPOKEN 재미없어요 *je-mi-uhp-suh-yo*

방금 그건 좀 재미없었어요 ㅎㅎ

bang-geum geu-guhn jom je-mi-uhp-suh-ssuh-yo ㅎㅎ

That one just now was kinda not funny haha.

-은/는 'that one just now.' 그것은 → 그건 (topic).

재미없다 'wasn't fun / fell flat.' The ㅎㅎ softens the blow.

CATEGORY 10 Temperature & Weather

온도 · 날씨

덥다 to be hot (weather)

SPOKEN 더워요 *duh-wuh-yo*

더워 죽을 것 같아요

duh-wuh joo-geul guht ga-ta-yo

I'm dying of heat!

~아/어 죽을 것 같다 Hyperbole 'dying of heat' (rarely literal!). 덥다 = weather / how you feel. (ㄷ irregular → 더워요.)

춥다 to be cold (weather)

SPOKEN 추워요 *choo-wuh-yo*

제 나라가 훨씬 더 추워요

je na-ra-ga hwuhl-ssin duh choo-wuh-yo

My country is way colder.

훨씬 더 'much more.'

춥다 For weather / how you feel. Pair-mate: 차갑다 (cold to the touch). (ㄷ irregular.)

따뜻하다 to be warm

SPOKEN 따뜻해요 *tta-tteu-te-yo*

따뜻한 아메리카노 하나 주세요

tta-tteu-tan a-me-ri-ka-no ha-na joo-se-yo

One hot americano, please.

-(으)ㄴ 'hot / warm' (modifier). Koreans order drinks 따뜻한 / 아이스. Also 'warm-hearted.'

하나 주세요 'one, please.'

시원하다 to be cool / refreshing

SPOKEN 시원해요 *shi-wuhn-he-yo*

오늘은 왠지 시원한 거 땡겨요

o-neu-reun wen-ji shi-wuhn-han guh tteng-gyuh-yo

For some reason I'm craving something cool today.

왠지 'for some reason.'

-(으)ㄴ 거 'something cool.' Fun: a hot, hearty soup is also 시원하다 ('refreshing')!

땡기다 'I'm craving it.' 땡기다(=당기다) = to crave.

뜨겁다 to be hot (object)

SPOKEN 뜨거워요 *tteu-guh-wuh-yo*

많이 뜨거워요 조심해요

ma-ni tteu-guh-wuh-yo jo-shim-he-yo

It's very hot, be careful.

많이 'very.'

뜨겁다 For things that burn — coffee, pans. NOT weather (that's 덥다). (ㅂ irregular.)

조심해요 'be careful.'

차갑다 to be cold (object / person)

SPOKEN 차가워요 *cha-ga-wuh-yo*

되게 차가운 사람인 줄 알았어요

dwe-ge cha-ga-on sa-ra-min jool a-ra-ssuh-yo

I thought you were a cold/distant person.

되게 'really / super' (casual).

-(으)ㄴ 'a cold person' — 차갑다 also for cold personalities! (ㅂ irregular.)

-(으)ㄴ 줄 알았다 'I thought (you) were ~' — a mistaken assumption.

습하다 to be humid

SPOKEN 습해요 *seu-pe-yo*

요즘 날씨 너무 습하고 더워요

yo-jeum nal-ssi nuh-moo seu-pa-go duh-wuh-yo

The weather's so humid and hot these days.

요즘 'these days.'

-고 'humid and ~.' 고 links two adjectives. Korea's summers are famously 습하고 더워요.

건조하다 to be dry

SPOKEN 건조해요 *guh-n-jo-he-yo*

저희 나라는 건조하고 더워서 괜찮아요

juh-hui na-ra-neun guhn-jo-ha-go duh-wuh-suh gwen-cha-na-yo

My country is a dry heat, so it's bearable.

-는 'as for my country.' 저희 = our (humble).

-고 'dry and ~.' For weather and skin.

-아/어서 'because it's hot' → a dry heat, so it's bearable.

흐리다 to be cloudy / overcast

SPOKEN 흐려요 *heu-ryuh-yo*

오늘 날이 흐려서 기분이 별로 안 좋아요

o-neul na-ri heu-ryuh-suh gi-boo-ni byuhl-lo an jo-a-yo

It's gloomy out today, so I'm not in a great mood.

-아/어서 'because it's overcast.' 날이 흐리다 = the sky is cloudy.

별로 안 ~ 'not that good.' 별로 = 'not really' (with a negative).

맑다 to be clear / sunny

SPOKEN 맑아요 mal-ga-yo

한숨 자고 일어나니 정신이 맑아졌어요

han-soom ja-go i-ruh-na-ni juhng-shi-ni mal-ga-jyuh-ssuh-yo

After a nap, my head cleared up.

-(으)니 'after sleeping and waking.' ~니 = 'upon ~ing.'

-아/어지다 'my head cleared up.' 맑아지다 = to become clear. (받침 ㄹ, [말가요].)

쌀쌀하다 to be chilly

SPOKEN 쌀쌀해요 ssal-ssal-he-yo

오늘 저녁에 쌀쌀하니 외투 챙겨요!

o-neul juh-nyuh-ge ssal-ssal-ha-ni we-too cheng-gyuh-yo!

It'll be chilly tonight, so grab a coat!

-(으)니 'since it's chilly.' That jacket-needed cold of early autumn.

챙기다 'grab a coat.' 챙기다 = to take / pack along.

CATEGORY 11 Taste

맛

맛있다 to be delicious

SPOKEN 맛있어요 ma-shi-ssuh-yo

올해 먹은 것 중에 제일 맛있어요

ol-he muh-geun guht joong-e je-il ma-shi-ssuh-yo

It's the tastiest thing I've had this year.

-(으)ㄴ 것 중에 'among the things (I've) eaten.' ~ㄴ 것 중에 = 'of all the ~.'

제일 'the most.'

맛있다 맛 + 있다. Casually said [마시썌요]. Modifier 맛있는.

맛없다 to be tasteless / bad

SPOKEN 맛없어요 ma-duhp-suh-yo

음 가지 진짜 맛없어요

euk ga-ji jin-jja ma-duhp-suh-yo

Ugh, eggplant is really gross.

음 'ugh' — a spoken cringe.

가지 'eggplant.'

맛없다 맛 + 없다. Said [마덜썌요]. The blunt opposite of 맛있다.

달다 to be sweet

SPOKEN 달아요 da-ra-yo

한국 음식은 전반적으로 달아요

han-gook eum-shi-geun juhn-ban-juh-geu-ro da-ra-yo

Korean food is sweet overall.

전반적으로 'overall / generally.'

달다 ⇨ irregular: the modifier drops ⇨ → 단 (단 거 = 'sweet stuff').

쓰다 to be bitter

SPOKEN 써요 ssuh-yo

녹차의 쓴 맛이 좋아요

nok-cha-ui sseun ma-shi jo-a-yo

I like the bitter taste of green tea.

-의 'of green tea.' -의 = 's / of.'

-(으)ㄴ 'bitter taste.' (쓰다 — irregular → 써요; modifier 쓴.) Homophone of 쓰다 'use/write.'

짜다 to be salty

SPOKEN 짜요 jja-yo

살짝 짜요

sal-jjak jja-yo

It's a little salty.

살짝 'slightly.'

짜다 (짜다 also = 'to squeeze,' by context.)

맵다 to be spicy

SPOKEN 맵워요 me-wuh-yo

매운 거 잘 못 먹어요

me-oon guh jal mot muh-guh-yo

I can't handle spicy food.

-(으)ㄴ 'spicy stuff.' (맵다 ⇨ irregular → 맵워요.)

잘 못 ~ 'can't handle ~.' A must-know line in spice-loving Korea.

싱겁다 to be bland

SPOKEN 싱거워요 shing-guh-wuh-yo

조금 싱거운데 소금 있어요?

jo-geum shing-guh-oon-de so-geum i-ssuh-yo?

It's a bit bland — do you have salt?

-(으)ㄴ데 'it's a bit bland, so...' Under-seasoned. (⇨ irregular → 싱거워요.)

소금 있어요? 'do you have salt?'

시다 to be sour

SPOKEN 셔요 shyuh-yo

너무 셔요! 물 좀 주세요!

nuh-moo shyuh-yo! mool jom joo-se-yo!

So sour! Water, please!

시다 시+어요 → 셔요; modifier 신 (신 거). Think lemons, unripe fruit.

좀 'just' — softens 물 주세요 into a gentler request.

CATEGORY 12 Senses — Light, Sound, Distance & Speed

감각 · 빛 · 소리 · 거리 · 속도

밝다 to be bright

SPOKEN 밝아요 bal-ga-yo

전 밝은 사람이 좋아요

juhn bal-geun sa-ra-mi jo-a-yo

I like cheerful people.

-는 'as for me' (저는 → 전).

-(으)ㄴ 'a cheerful person.' 밝다 = bright AND sunny in personality. (받침 ㄹ, [발가요].)

어둡다 to be dark

SPOKEN 어두워요 uh-doo-wuh-yo

너무 어두워요? 불 켜 줄까요?

nuh-moo uh-doo-wuh-yo? bool kyuh jool-kka-yo?

Is it too dark? Shall I turn on the light?

어둡다 For darkness and mood. (ㄹ irregular.)

-아/어 줄까요? Offering 'shall I ~ for you?' = 'want me to turn on the light?'

조용하다 to be quiet

SPOKEN 조용해요 jo-yong-he-yo

여기 조용히 해야 하나 봐요

yuh-gi jo-yong-hi he-ya ha-na bwa-yo

Seems we should be quiet here.

조용히 'quietly' (adverb).

-나 보다 'it seems we should ~.' ~나 봐요 = 'it seems (that).'

시끄럽다 to be noisy / loud

SPOKEN 시끄러워요 shi-kkeu-ruh-wuh-yo

조금 시끄러운데 다른 데 갈까요?

jo-geum shi-kkeu-ruh-oon-de da-reun de gal-kka-yo?

It's a bit loud — shall we go somewhere else?

-(으)ㄴ데 'it's a bit loud, so...' (ㄹ irregular → 시끄러워요.)

다른 데 'somewhere else.' 데 = place.

가깝다 to be near / close

SPOKEN **가까워요** *ga-kka-wuh-yo*

여기서 가까워요?

yuh-gi-suh ga-kka-wuh-yo?

Is it near here?

-에서 'from here.' 여기서 = 여기|에서.

가깝다 For distance and also relationships. (ㄹ irregular.)

멀다 to be far

SPOKEN **멀어요** *muh-ruh-yo*

너무 먼데 택시 탈까요?

nuh-moo muhn-de tek-ssi tal-kka-yo?

It's too far — shall we take a taxi?

-(으)나데 'it's too far, so...' 멀다 → modifier drops ㄹ → **먼**. (ㄹ irregular.)

-(으)까요? Suggestion 'shall we take a taxi?'

빠르다 to be fast

SPOKEN **빨라요** *ppal-la-yo*

밥 왜 이렇게 빨리 먹어요?

bap we i-ruh-ke ppal-li muh-guh-yo?

Why do you eat so fast?

왜 이렇게 ~ A playful 'why so ~?', reacting to the speed.

빨리 'quickly' (adverb). (빠르다 ㄹ irregular → 빨라요.)

느리다 to be slow

SPOKEN **느려요** *neu-ryuh-yo*

제 걸음이 좀 느려서 천천히 가 주세요 ㅎㅎ

je guh-reu-mi jom neu-ryuh-suh chuhn-chuhn-hi ga joo-se-yo ㅎㅎ

I walk a bit slow, so please go slowly haha.

걸음이 '(my) walking pace.' 걸음 = a step / pace.

-아/어서 'because I'm slow.' (느리다 is regular → 느려요.)

-아/어 주세요 'please go (slowly) for me.'